

The bit on Indian is something I now think about a lot because it means bringing cultural nuances. I live in New York City and I invite people home—[they] could be my team, clients, and everybody asks, ‘You are going to have a dinner at home?’ It’s a very normal Indian thing to do. I spent all these years trying to fit into the US way of doing things and I reached a certain point when I told myself that’s the wrong approach.

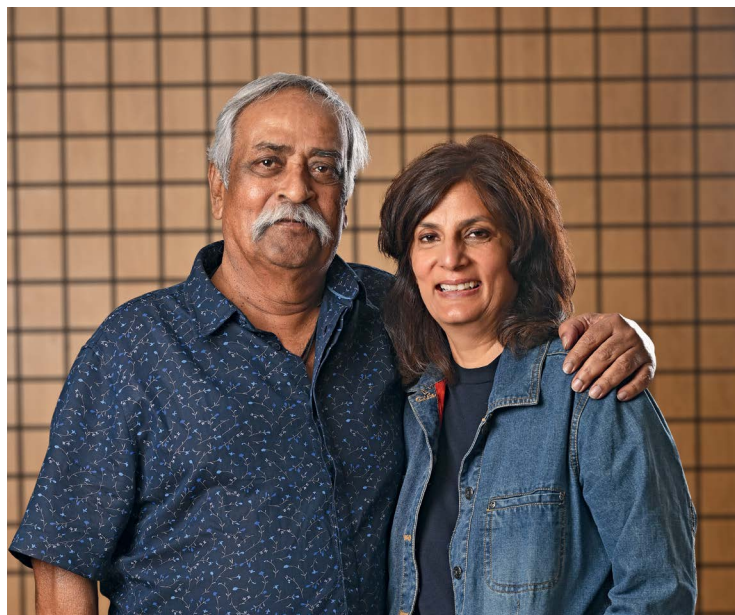
Q: What was the tipping point?

DB: The first seven years in the US were about wanting to belong (I moved there in 1993). I was not very comfortable and spent a lot of time with Indians. My son was born and I did not want to raise him in a little bubble of Indianness. If I did that, there was no point being in the US and I could have just moved back. It was important to make that effort to embrace American culture and put myself out of my own comfort zone. Then, I spent a period of my time wanting to fit in, make friends and break the boundaries. Then you reach a point where you realise you have done all of that. Now, it is time to get back to the roots since you have a seat at the table and I want to do that as an Indian.

42 | Q: You have over 70 years of experience between yourselves. Why is the present moment so exciting as far as being in advertising goes?

PP: The opportunity to express that you are Indian and your Indianness and then be expressive about a whole lot of things is the greatest. My idea can reach people in the most unexpected places and to me that’s the big excitement.

DB: If I go back 10-15 years, advertising was a lot simpler and we did not have the media landscape of today. But we also did not have the ability to do the kind of things we do now. At a very basic level, the ability to touch hearts and minds of people is exciting. Today, we can change the course of society and culture or policy. Take Dove and the Crown Act (known as the Crown Act, it stands for Create a Respectful and Open World for Natural Hair to ensure protection against discrimination based on race-based hairstyles) in the US and ratified in over 26 states. We could not have dreamt of this 10 years ago. Or the kids online safety Act (the bill ‘sets out requirements’ to protect minors from ‘harm’ on social media platforms) again with Dove. In Honduras, using the morning-after pill (it was the only nation in the Americas with an absolute ban on both the sale and use of emergency contraception, referred to as the morning-after or Plan B pills) could lead to women being imprisoned for six years even if they were raped. With a creative idea, a law was changed and it was legalised. When people say, ‘Those were the days,’ my view is, ‘The days are now!’ Yes, there is a greater level



of complication, but there is much more potential to do things that will have a shelf life beyond our own lives.

Q: What kind of complications are you speaking of in a broad sense?

DB: There is technology, data, plus media fragmentation. All that leads to complications.

PP: There is also too much of information. Complications mean you get so influenced by all this and you want me to follow this data. Suddenly, you forget why you wanted to use that data in the first place. That kind of slavery to technology becomes a complication.

Q: How can you get past that?

DB: I don’t think it’s about getting past data. Rather, you must embrace the usefulness of it. But we are only